

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

THIS BOOK IS DIVIDED INTO six continental sections – North America, Central and South America, Europe, Asia, Africa, and Australasia and Oceania. At the start of each section there is a map showing the whole continent, and pages describing the peoples who live there. Each country, or group of countries, then has an individual map showing its cities, towns, and

main geographical features. This is followed by country pages that go into detail about life in the countries. The reference section can be used to find out more about subjects of general interest, such as world religions or political systems. There is also a glossary, a gazetteer, and an index. These two pages explain the symbols and information found throughout the book.

COUNTRY PAGES

The country pages, like this one for Japan, have been designed to give you as much information as possible about the way of life in a country – its people, their traditions, politics, and the economy. All the countries of the world are featured in the book.

FACT BOXES

Each country page has a box with important statistics about that country, such as its area, the size of its population, its capital city, and its currency. The notes below explain some other entries that appear in most fact boxes.



Locator map
This shows the position of a country, or countries, in relation to its neighbors. This locator map shows where Japan lies off the coast of mainland Asia.

JAPAN

Capital city: Tokyo

Area: 145,882 sq miles (377,835 sq km)

Population: 128,000,000

Official language: Japanese

Major religions: Shinto and Buddhist 92%, other 8%

Government: Multiparty democracy

Currency: Yen

Adult literacy rate: 99%

Life expectancy: 82 years

People per doctor: 496

Televisions: 707 per 1,000 people

People per doctor

This figure shows how many people there are for every one doctor. It gives a rough guide as to whether people have easy access to medical attention. Find out more on page 276.

Major religions

The figures provide a breakdown of the religious beliefs of the people. All the main religions are explained in detail on pages 274–275.

Government

This describes how a country is ruled, or governed. The main types of government are explained on pages 270–271.

Adult literacy rate

This is the percentage of people in a country that can read and write. Literacy rates are based on the ability of people aged 15 or over to read and write a simple sentence. Find out more about literacy on page 277.

Life expectancy

The number shows how long the average person in a country can expect to live. Figures are a combination of the average life expectancy for men and women. There is more about life expectancy on page 276.

COLOR BORDERS

Each continental section has a different color border to help you locate that section easily. This page on Japan has the color used for all the countries in Asia.

HEADING

Every page in the book has a heading telling you the name of the section followed by the name of the country featured on that page.

JAPAN

FOR MANY CENTURIES, Japan was closed to foreigners and wary of the outside world. Today, it is a leading industrial and technological power and one of the world's richest countries. This transformation is even more remarkable given Japan's mountainous landscape and lack of natural resources. Most raw materials have to be imported from abroad. Japanese people enjoy a high standard of living, with good health care and education systems. Average life expectancy in Japan is among the highest in the world. Western influence is strong, but people remain proud of their culture and traditions.

ECONOMIC STRENGTH
Japan has a highly developed infrastructure and industrial base. One of the main reasons why the country's industries have grown so quickly is that the Japanese are very hardworking. Many of the larger companies are like families, providing housing and health care for their employees. However, society is slowly changing. Young people are starting to question this working culture, especially as the economy began to slow down in the 1990s, and unemployment rose.

CHERRY BLOSSOMS
Japanese people share a love of nature and pay close attention to the changing seasons. The blossoming of cherry trees is a celebrated time of year. The first blossoms appear in southern Kyushu. Their progress is plotted on maps shown on television news. The blossoms last for a few days, and people celebrate by picnicking under the cherry trees.

RELIGION
Shinto and Buddhism, the two major religions of Japan, have been merged together in a certain extent. Most Japanese people consider themselves Buddhist, Shintoist, or Shinto-Buddhist. There is also a significant Christian community, making it the third most populous religion in Japan.

OVERCROWDING
With a large population and a lack of flat land for settlement, Japan is a crowded country. Land is expensive, especially in the cities, and many people commute long distances to work. During rush hours, subway trains are so crowded that guards have to push commuters on board. The uncomfortable journeys that people endure inspired Japanese technicians to invent personal stereos so people could listen to music while traveling.

CHILDREN'S LIVES
Children are well taken care of in Japan. There is even a national holiday, Children's Day, celebrated on May 5. On this day, children are dressed in traditional clothing and taken to religious festivals. Japanese children are expected to study hard at school. In addition to a long school day, many people attend evening classes in ballet and the arts.

FISHING FOR FOOD
As a nation of islands, Japan depends heavily on the surrounding seas for food. The Japanese catch and eat more fish than any other country, and have the largest fishing fleet in the world. There are hundreds of villages dotted along the coast from which small fishing boats venture out, while deep-sea fish are caught by larger trawlers. Some factories that process the catch on board. Millions of fish are also bred each year on fish farms.

TRADITIONAL DRESS
People in Japan wear kimonos for religious festivals and other special occasions. A kimono (which means "sliding") is a long-sleeved, wrap-around robe with a belt called an obi. It may be made of silk, cotton, or wool. Many formal silk kimonos are richly colored and beautifully embroidered.

FESTIVALS
There are plenty of festivals in Japan, each with their own traditions. The parade floats (dashi) are decorated with floats and lanterns. In the festival, floats are pulled by teams of men, and the floats are decorated with floats and lanterns.

SPORTING LIFE
Whether working or taking part, Japanese people love sports. The national team sport is baseball, which is known as the "national sport" in Japan. Japan has won the U.S. Olympic sport medal in baseball. Success in the ring depends on weight and strength, so wrestlers follow high-protein diets.

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Abbreviations used in the book:

Imperial

ft	feet
in	inches
sq miles	square miles
mph	miles per hour
°F	degrees Fahrenheit

Metric

m	meters
mm	millimeters
cm	centimeters
km	kilometers
sq km	square kilometers
km/h	kilometers per hour
°C	degrees Centigrade

Other abbreviations

BC	Before Christ
AD	Anno Domini
US	United States
UK	United Kingdom

Find out more

EARTHQUAKES: 13
GROWING CITIES: 17, 136
LIFE EXPECTANCY: 276
PACIFIC RIM ECONOMIES: 137

FIND OUT MORE BOXES

At the end of each country entry there is a Find out more box. This directs you to other pages in the book where you can discover more about a particular subject. For example, one of the pages on Japan explains how the country suffers from hundreds of earthquakes a year. You can find out more about earthquakes and why they occur by turning to page 13 in the book.